

FOSS Helps Naaptol Take E-Commerce to New Heights!



Naaptol, a leading virtual home shopping platform, grew phenomenally by placing its bets on open source technology. Adopting the FOSS model not only helped the e-commerce giant cut down on its early investments, but also proved to be a great enabler in the long run.

Open source software has spawned quite a few success stories, with each one indicating the growing acceptance of FOSS at the enterprise level. The classic example of Naaptol, the online retail giant, shows that companies, irrespective of their size, can leverage FOSS and enjoy its benefits forever.

The brainchild of an IITian, Manu Agarwal, Naaptol has grown into a company with a revenue of Rs 2000 million in a span of just five years. It has witnessed phenomenal growth, both in terms of products and revenue. Today, the e-commerce platform sells 200,000 products and 500 brands on its portal. What started out as a three to four member group has today evolved into a company that boasts of a robust team of 500 people comprising the right mix of open source developers and evangelists.

What's interesting is that Naaptol depends almost 100 per cent on open source tools to optimise its IT costs and, therefore, 'all things FOSS' seems to be the mantra of the online retailer.

Chief technology officer at Naaptol, Mahendra Patil, who describes himself as a true blue Linux and Java professional, was happy to share the online retail giant's tryst with open

source. Deploying open source solutions was high on the priority list from the day Naaptol was launched in 2008, in an attempt to cut initial investments. As a result, the online retailer claims to have saved approximately 80 per cent on its preliminary costs. Witnessing the application turn into a great success, the owners decided to use this to scale their venture and enhance their business' profitability. "I have been in the open source industry for more than 12 years. Right from the baby steps of Naaptol, we adopted open source solutions in different areas like the Naaptol Application Platform, the infrastructure development environment, and in domains like quality and testing, performance benchmarking, debugging and more," says Patil.

Why the 'open' model?

Apart from being cost-effective, FOSS helped Naaptol in a number of ways. Giving the lowdown on all the factors, Patil explains, "Open source is indeed cool, as there is a wide range of open source software available in the market to suit your IT requirements. From the early days at Naaptol, we tried out a varied range of open source tools and these helped us. We could even develop our own